THE POLICE VERSUS THE NIA



AP

DEATH BLOW
Security personnel carrying the body of a victim at Jheeram Ghati, May 2013

By Rahul Noronha

Perhaps the ghost of the Jheeram Ghati massacre will be finally laid to rest. A decade after the deadly political slaughter took place on May 25, 2013, and following a protracted legal battle, the Supreme Court on November 21 issued an order granting the Chhattisgarh police autonomy to investigate it. In doing so it overruled the opposition of the National Investigation Agency (NIA), which had been probing the case, to the involvement of the state police in the investigation. The Bhupesh Baghel government had long asserted that the NIA probe had overlooked the conspiracy angle in the case, and the state police therefore be allowed to investigate the incident.

On that fateful day 10 years back, heavily armed Maoists had ambushed a convoy of Congress leaders in the Jheeram Ghati area of Jagdalpur district, killing more than 30 people, including top Congress leaders Vidya Charan Shukla, then state Congress president Nand Kumar Patel, former MP Mahendra Karma and former MLA Uday Mudaliyar. The leaders were returning from Sukma, where they had participated in a programme organised as part of the party's *parivartan yatra*. The state was to go to the polls later the same year.

THE CONGRESS GOVERNMENT CLAIMS THE NIA PROBE OVERLOOKED THE CONSPIRACY ANGLE

The verdict has sparked off a wave of political reactions from both the BJP and Congress. BJP leader and former chief minister Raman Singh said his party would promptly get the matter investigated once it came to power. "The person who kept saying he has evidence of the conspiracy in his pocket did not produce it before the NIA that has been investigating the matter for the past five years," said Singh, blaming CM Baghel for not coming up with proof to back his claims.

Baghel took to social media platform X to say that the law will now take its course. "The Chhattisgarh police will now probe the conspiracy angle in the case, who hatched it and with whom. When the police began investigating, the NIA approached the court to disrupt it," he said.

When the massacre took place, the political and security establishment was flummoxed at the level of violence against the politicians. The Maoists had till then restricted themselves to targeting security personnel and forest department staff. It was Karma in particular that their brutal ire was directed against, owing to his role as a supporter of Salwa Judum, a state-sponsored vigilante movement against them. While a number of Congress functionaries and security personnel accompanying them were killed in the incident, the execution of Patel and his son Dinesh later lent credence to several conspiracy theories.

The UPA government at the Centre had immediately ordered a probe by the NIA after the incident. The